The True Cost of Quitting

By Gavin Cook — Chief Instructor, Train Taekwondo Schools *5th Dan Black Belt · TAGB Certified · 43 Years Training · 15 Years Running the Club*

I want to have an honest conversation with you — parent to parent.

Because I have two sons, Harry and Jack, who have both trained in Taekwondo since the age of five. I know exactly what it feels like to sit in a car after a tough class and hear "I don't want to go any more." I know the temptation to say "okay, love" and let it go.

But I also know what happens to the children who stay.

This document is about that. It is about the real cost of quitting — not just the money, though we will get to that — but the cost in confidence, in character, in academic achievement, and in lifetime earnings potential. Because the research on this is extraordinary, and I think every parent deserves to see it laid out plainly.

Part One: The £920 Question

Let me ask you something.

Imagine your son or daughter came to you and said they wanted to do a two-year specialist course. A course that would teach them discipline, focus, resilience, goal-setting, leadership, and self-confidence. A course with a structured syllabus, regular assessments, and a nationally recognised qualification at the end. A course run by a fully qualified instructor with over 40 years of experience.

The cost? **£920 over two years.** That is roughly £8.50 a week — less than a family trip to McDonald's.

Now imagine they completed that course. How would you feel?

Proud. Absolutely proud. You would tell people. You would frame the certificate. You would know that your child had done something that the vast majority of people who start never finish.

Now imagine they quit halfway through.

How would you feel then?

Not angry — I am not suggesting that. But a little deflated, perhaps. A little aware that something was left unfinished. That a skill was half-built. That a lesson in perseverance was not quite learned.

That is exactly what happens when a child quits Taekwondo before their black belt.

The two-year journey from white belt to black belt at Train Taekwondo Schools costs approximately **£920 in total** — including all lessons, gradings, and equipment. That is the same as a short college access course. The same as a driving theory and practical preparation programme. The same as a year of music lessons with a private tutor.

The difference is that Taekwondo does not just teach one skill. It teaches the *ability to learn* — and that, as you are about to see, is worth considerably more than £920.

Part Two: What Finishing Actually Teaches

Here is what I have observed in 15 years of running this club, and what the science now confirms.

The children who reach their black belt are not the most naturally talented. They are not always the fastest or the most coordinated. They are the ones who learned to show up when it was hard. The ones who failed a grading and came back. The ones who had a bad week at school and still walked onto the mat.

That quality has a name. Psychologists call it **GRIT** — the combination of Growth, Resilience, Intrinsic motivation, and Tenacity. It is the single greatest non-cognitive predictor of long-term success in education, career, and life.

A landmark study published in the *International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health* (Lee et al., 2021) followed 305 university students — some who trained in Taekwondo, some who did not — over a full academic year. The findings were striking:

> *"The higher the Taekwondo ability, the higher the academic achievement and the higher the GRIT. Moreover, the higher the GRIT, the higher the academic achievement. Taekwondo training increased the GRIT values of participants."*

This was not a small effect. The students who trained in Taekwondo showed measurably greater GRIT scores and significantly better academic results than those who did not — even when controlling for prior ability.

A separate study published in *Frontiers in Psychology* (2025), examining four Taekwondo academies in the United States, found that the black belt journey specifically develops three life skills that transfer directly into academic and professional success: **perseverance, integrity, and leadership**. These were not incidental outcomes. They were embedded in the curriculum — taught deliberately through the belt system itself.

And a major European randomised controlled trial involving 721 children across five countries found that children who trained in martial arts showed **significantly better academic achievement** and **reduced conduct problems** compared to children in standard physical education — after just one year of training.

Part Three: Martial Arts Students Outperform Everyone Else Academically

I want to be precise here, because the research is specific.

A 2021 study published in the *International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health* compared three groups of children: those who trained in martial arts, those who played team sports, and those who did no sport at all. The results were unambiguous:

> *"Children practicing martial arts showed better executive functioning and higher school marks than those involved in team sports or not involved in any sports."*

Not just better than sedentary children. Better than children playing football, basketball, and other team sports.

Why? Because martial arts is unique in what it demands from the brain. Every session requires sustained attention, working memory, inhibitory control, and cognitive flexibility — the four core executive functions that neuroscientists identify as the strongest predictors of academic success. The belt system adds structured goal-setting on top of that. And the grading process teaches children to perform under pressure — a skill that transfers directly to examinations.

Research published in *Developmental Psychology* and the *Journal of Cognitive Enhancement* has found that martial arts training improves attention spans by up to **30%** compared to control groups. Teachers consistently report that children who train in

martial arts demonstrate better classroom behaviour, improved concentration, and a more proactive approach to learning.

These are not soft benefits. These are measurable, documented, peer-reviewed outcomes.

Part Four: The Black Belt and the Degree — What the Numbers Tell Us

Here is the section I find most compelling, and the one I think every parent should read carefully.

Only **3 in every 100 people** who start martial arts training ever reach black belt. The dropout rate is extraordinary — roughly 60% quit within the first six months, and nearly 80% have stopped training by the end of the first year. Of those who remain, the vast majority drop out before they reach the intermediate belts.

The students who reach black belt are, by definition, a self-selected group of exceptional completers. They have demonstrated — over three to four years of consistent effort — that they can set a long-term goal and see it through.

Now compare that to UK university degree completion rates.

According to the Higher Education Statistics Agency (HESA), approximately **6.3% of UK university students drop out** before completing their degree. That figure rises significantly when you look at specific institutions and subjects — in some universities, the dropout rate exceeds 18%. Globally, the figure is closer to 30%.

The students who complete their degrees — who push through the second-year slump, who submit the dissertation, who sit the final examinations — share a common trait with black belt earners. They finish what they start.

Research by Buzzetto-Hollywood (2019), published in *Issues in Informing Science and Information Technology*, followed students longitudinally and found a **significant positive correlation between higher GRIT scores and both GPA and persistence to graduation**. Students with higher GRIT were not just more likely to get better grades — they were more likely to complete their degree at all.

A 2024 study published in the *Journal of College Student Retention* found that higher GRIT scores significantly predicted both **increased graduation rates and decreased dropout rates**, even after controlling for academic ability, gender, and socioeconomic background.

The connection is not coincidental. The child who earns their black belt has spent three to four years practising exactly the psychological skills that predict degree completion: delayed gratification, persistence through difficulty, goal-directed behaviour, and the ability to perform under pressure.

I cannot tell you that every black belt earner will complete a university degree. But I can tell you this with confidence: **the skills that earn a black belt are the same skills that complete a degree.** And the research backs that up entirely.

Part Five: What a Degree Is Actually Worth

I want to put some numbers on the table, because I think parents deserve to see the full picture.

The Institute for Fiscal Studies — the UK's most respected independent economic research body — published a comprehensive analysis of the lifetime earnings impact of undergraduate degrees. Their findings, based on tracking real individuals through school, university, and into the labour market, were as follows:

The **gross difference in lifetime earnings** between graduates and non-graduates is **£430,000 for men and £260,000 for women**.

Once you account for differences in background characteristics and apply the current tax and student loan system, the **net lifetime earnings premium** is approximately **£130,000 for men and £100,000 for women** — equivalent to a 20% gain in average net lifetime earnings across a working life.

To put that in context: the cost of a three-year undergraduate degree in England is currently around £27,750 in tuition fees alone, plus living costs. The return on that investment — even in net terms after tax and loan repayments — is still substantial for the majority of graduates.

But here is the critical point that parents often miss.

You only capture that return if you complete the degree.

A student who drops out in their second year has incurred the debt without earning the qualification. They have paid the cost without receiving the benefit. And according to HESA data, the students most likely to drop out are those who struggle with self-regulation, sustained motivation, and the ability to persist through difficulty — precisely the skills that martial arts training builds.

The research on childhood sporting activities and adult labour market outcomes (Cabane and Clark, *Annals of Economics and Statistics*, 2015) found a **4% higher graduation rate for men and a 9% higher graduation rate for women** who participated in structured sport during childhood, compared to those who did not. Individual sports — where the child is personally accountable for their own progress, rather than able to hide within a team — showed the strongest effects.

Taekwondo is the ultimate individual sport. Every grading, every belt, every technique is yours alone. You cannot rely on a teammate to cover for you. You show up, you perform, and you are assessed on your own merit. That is exactly the environment that builds the self-reliance and personal accountability that predicts degree completion.

Part Six: The Numbers Side by Side

What you invest	Cost	What you get
Two years of Taekwondo to black belt	£920	Nationally recognised TAGB qualification, documented life skills, measurably improved executive function, GRIT, self-discipline, confidence
Three-year undergraduate degree	£27,750+ tuition	£100,000–£130,000 net lifetime earnings premium (if completed)
Quitting Taekwondo at green belt	£0 saved	Half-built skills, an unfinished goal, and a lesson in giving up when things get hard

The child who quits at green belt has not saved £460. They have spent £460 on a half-finished course and walked away without the qualification, without the life skills, and — most importantly — without the experience of finishing something difficult.

That experience of finishing something difficult is, in my view, the most valuable thing Taekwondo gives a child. Not the kicks. Not the belts. The knowledge — deep in their bones — that they can set a hard goal, work through the obstacles, and come out the other side.

Part Seven: A Word From Me, Directly

I have been teaching Taekwondo for over 40 years. I have watched hundreds of children come through this club. I have seen the ones who quit and the ones who stayed.

The ones who stayed are not all professional athletes. They are not all martial arts instructors. They are teachers, engineers, nurses, business owners, and parents themselves. What they have in common is not Taekwondo. It is the character that Taekwondo helped them build.

When a parent tells me their child wants to quit, I always ask one question: *Is this what your child wants, or is this what your child wants right now?*

There is a difference. Children want to quit when things are hard. That is not a reason to quit — that is the reason to stay. The hard part is where the growth happens. The hard part is where the character is built. The hard part is where the GRIT is forged.

The £920 you invest in your child's black belt journey is not a leisure expense. It is an investment in the cognitive skills, the psychological resilience, and the academic habits that will shape their performance in every classroom, every examination room, and every workplace they ever enter.

I have seen it happen too many times to doubt it.

The question is not whether your child can earn their black belt. Every child who walks through our door can earn their black belt, given time and consistency.

The question is whether you will give them the chance to find that out.

The Research Behind This Document

The following peer-reviewed studies and institutional reports informed the content of this document:

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